effect that, before 2005, Bihar was a wasteland of lawlessness under Lalu Prasad Yadav, and only under Nitish did governance and development take root. Even Tejaswi, during the 2020 polls, held a careful line, offering a muted apology for his father's tenure while crafting a new identity of his own.

Now, he has abandoned that restraint. No longer willing to play defence, he is actively reclaiming Lalu's legacy—not as a liability, but as a badge of honour. Rather than shying away from the inevitable rhetorical attack—"Was there anything before 2005?"—Tejaswi has armed himself with historical records to flip the script. His argument: Lalu's tenure was one of social transformation. "The first achievement of Lalu Prasad since 1990 was to provide a stable government after Bihar had experienced 22 changes of government and five periods of President's rule since 1961," he declared. "He orchestrated social empowerment—achievements that were unprecedented in the preceding 150 years. It was under Lalu Prasad that individuals from EBC, OBC and SC communities ascended to roles as MPs, ministers and heads of boards and commissions."

TEJASWI'S DECISION TO EMBRACE THE RJD'S LEGACY SIGNALS A NEWFOUND CLARITY IN HIS APPROACH

This calculated shift marks a fundamental transformation in Bihar's electoral discourse. As the state inches toward another high-stakes election, Tejaswi is not retreating into damage control but rather attempting to rewrite the playbook itself. ■

BJP

SEARCH DEEPENS FOR A NEW BOSS

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Euphoric after the poll victories in three states, the BJP has 'renewed' the search for a new party president to succeed Jagat Prakash Nadda. The BJP chief's tenure is for three years, but Nadda has held the post since 2019—getting one extension after another, the last to ensure "continuity" in the preparations for the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. To form the electoral college that will formally vote for a new president, the BJP constitution requires that at least half the state units have elected their own presidents. That part of the process has also seen big delays.

Party sources say this was because the leadership was concentrating more on the series of state assembly elections in the second half of 2024, but it's also true that some of the key state units are riven with factionalism. Finally, in December, the process to fill the posts in the states was initiated in 29 of the 36 states and UTs, but has so far come to fruition in only 13; Bihar and Rajasthan are the only two big states in the list. The problem has been compounded by the fact that, since last June, Nadda has also been doubling up as the Union minister for health and family welfare, expediency dictating a rare infringement of the BJP's 'one person one post' rule.

The choosing of a new president during a crucial passage for the party, a time when it is looking to steer a generational shift. Few would disagree that the BJP is at its peak now, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's regime into its third straight term, and the party, along with allies, in power in 22 states (and UTs).

The BJP leadership may have another round of consultations with the top leadership of ideological parent Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), but both sides say that "Modi's decision will be final". That said, the visible involvement of the Sangh in poll management since the LS election reverses has vouchsafed a phase of victories.



CLEARING THE HEIR
Nadda and Shah at a party function in Delhi

ANI